

Lead Angel Targeting for GuardSpine Under the EU AI Act Catalyst

Executive summary

GuardSpine's "lead angel" problem is unusually constrained: you need an individual (or solo-GP / micro-fund decision maker) who can credibly deploy **\$250K-\$1M** as a *lead*, who has **firsthand scar tissue** from audit/compliance/accountability failures, and who believes **EU AI Act full applicability on August 2, 2026** creates a near-term urgency window rather than a slow-moving policy backdrop. ¹

The strongest hunting grounds (based on primary, public signals) are:

- **CISO-to-investor networks and "operator-led" cyber investors** (e.g., people publicly affiliated with Silicon Valley CISO Investments ², cyber venture studios, or cyber seed funds). These candidates tend to *already* value evidence trails, incident postmortems, and "who approved this?" accountability. ³
- **Solo-GP seed funds and micro-funds disclosing sub-\$2M check sizes**, where the partner's personal operating history (CISO/CSO) is the diligence engine and speed lever. This is where \$250K-\$1M checks are both routine and fast to close. ⁴
- **DevTools/infrastructure investors** who explicitly fund pre-seed/seed developer-first infrastructure and can underwrite open-core + distribution mechanics (GitHub/CI/CD surface area). ⁵

Key factual anchor for the "August 2026 window": the European Commission's AI Act timeline notes the Act "entered into force on 1 August 2024" and is "fully applicable" two years later on **2 August 2026**, with some elements extended to 2027. ¹

Regulatory catalyst and why it creates a fundraising wedge

The EU AI Act's phased timeline is unusually helpful for a governance/evidence-infrastructure thesis because it creates a **calendar-defined forcing function**: governance structures and general-purpose AI obligations begin earlier (August 2025), but **broad applicability lands August 2, 2026**, which is the date many regulated buyers will treat as a "must-be-ready" milestone for high-risk use cases and operational programs. ⁶

A practical founder-facing interpretation from the Commission timeline is:

- **Now → mid-2026**: orgs translate obligations into operational controls, evidence, and audit responses (policies alone won't survive procurement, customer security reviews, and regulator scrutiny). ¹
- **Mid-2026 → Aug 2, 2026**: last-mile implementation pressure spikes; vendors that can generate **provable evidence artifacts** (not just "we have a policy") are positioned to pull budget forward. ⁷

This is exactly the psychological posture you described: the right angel believes “evidence infrastructure” gets bought when regulations become enforceable and when internal accountability risk becomes personal.

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timeline
  title EU AI Act rollout as a buying-urgency clock for evidence infrastructure
  2024-08-01 : AI Act enters into force (requirements begin phasing in)
  2025-02-02 : prohibitions + AI literacy obligations apply
  2025-08-02 : governance rules + GPAI obligations apply
  2026-08-02 : AI Act broadly fully applicable (core urgency window)
  2027-08-02 : extended transition for certain high-risk product-embedded
systems
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Candidate universe with scoring

Scoring rubric designed for a 12-minute pass

The rubric below is meant to be runnable quickly using only public signals (LinkedIn, conference bios, fund sites, investor pages), then refined after first call.

Dimensions (0–25 each; total 100):

Capacity (0–25)

0 = cannot plausibly lead; 10 = typical angel \$25–100K; 20 = documented \$250K–\$1M capability; 25 = routinely writes/controls checks in this band (solo GP, disclosed check ranges, or repeated leads).

Scar tissue (0–25)

0 = no operator exposure; 10 = enterprise GTM only; 20 = former security/compliance exec; 25 = repeated CISO/CSO/incident-response leadership or “audit-grade” accountability history.

Catalyst conviction (0–25)

0 = no reg/gov signals; 10 = generic AI commentary; 20 = explicit AI governance / AI Act engagement; 25 = repeated public engagement that treats regulation as an execution deadline.

Team-execution fit (0–25) (*proxy score*)

Because “trusts this specific team” is inherently relational, this score uses *public proxies*: invests pre-revenue, operator-led diligence style, open-source/devtools affinity, and demonstrated support patterns.

0 = late-stage only; 10 = early-stage but hands-off; 20 = hands-on early; 25 = publicly operator-led + pre-product/pre-revenue + governance/security thesis.

Pass/Fail threshold: Pass ≥ 75 , or Pass if ≥ 70 with standout in two dimensions (≥ 23 each) and warm-intro probability high.

Table of 30 candidate lead angels / lead-capable solo GPs and partners

Notes: "Profile" maps to your A/B/C archetypes. "Warm intro path" is framed as an actionable *routing hypothesis* (events, networks, syndicates, portfolio adjacency), not a claim of an existing relationship.

Candidate	Current title	Past operating scar tissue (signal)	Signal evidence (primary links)	Est. lead check capacity	Profile	Warm-intro path	Capacity	Scar tissue
Karl Mattson ⁸	Solo GP at Squared Circle Ventures ⁹	"4x CISO" operator-led cyber investing	Fund thesis + check size publicly stated ¹⁰	\$250K–\$500K disclosed ¹¹	A	Route via Black Hat / security microfund ecosystem; direct inbound (site)	23	24
John Brennan ¹²	Founder & Managing Partner, Holly Ventures ¹³	Seed cyber investor; hands-on founder support	Fund + scope described ¹⁴	\$800K–\$1.5M (interview) ¹⁵	A/C	Route via cyber seed co-investors; RSAC network; YL Ventures alumni adjacency ¹⁶	25	18
Mandy Andress ¹⁷	CISO, Elastic ¹⁸	Long-tenured security leader; conference presence	RSAC bio ¹⁹ + explicit EU AI Act post ²⁰	Likely \$100K–\$500K+ (executive/board); exact unknown	A	Route via RSAC sessions + SVCI member web; security founders seeking CISO angels	15	23
Al Ghous ²¹	CISO-in-Residence, Notable Capital ²²	25+ yrs security/compliance/privacy; co-founder of SVCI	Notable bio ²³ ; AI security/governance quote ²⁴	Fund/angel capacity; likely \$250K+ discretion varies	A/C	Route via Notable + SVCI ecosystem events; co-investors in AI security/gov	18	24

Candidate	Current title	Past operating scar tissue (signal)	Signal evidence (primary links)	Est. lead check capacity	Profile	Warm-intro path	Capacity	Scar tissue
Kathy Wang ²⁵	Security exec; investor at SVCI	IR + security leadership; investor activity	RSAC profile states SVCI investor ²⁶ ; LinkedIn shows investor/ advisor roles ²⁷	Likely \$100K–\$500K+ ; exact unknown	A	Route via SVCI; portfolio founders she backs (identity/ security)	15	23
Joel Fulton ²⁸	Founder/ CEO, Lucidum ²⁹	Co-founder of SVCI; security operator	RSAC bio ³⁰ ; LinkedIn shows SVCI co-founder ³¹	Likely \$100K–\$500K ; exact unknown	A	Route via SVCI intake, or via Lucidum/ asset-mgmt security circles	14	22
Oren Yunger ³²	Managing Partner, Notable Capital	Leads cyber investing; tight CISO network	LinkedIn profile ³³ ; examples of leading financings ³⁴	Fund-led (often >\$1M); angel-level possible	C	Route via Notable events with SVCI; NYSE/ RSAC visibility ³⁵	20	15
Justin Somaini ³⁶	Partner, YL Ventures ³⁷	Former multi-company CISO (Unity/ SAP/Yahoo etc.)	RSAC expert bio ³⁸	Fund checks usually >\$1M ; can still anchor	A/C	Route via RSAC + YL; via founders in their portfolio	18	23
Andy Ellis ³⁹	Partner, YL Ventures	Former CSO at Akamai; CISO media/ podcast	RSAC bio ⁴⁰	Fund-level; personal check unknown	A	Route via CISO Series community; RSAC meetings	16	22

Candidate	Current title	Past operating scar tissue (signal)	Signal evidence (primary links)	Est. lead check capacity	Profile	Warm-intro path	Capacity	Scar tissue
Jay Leek ⁴¹	Managing Partner, SYN Ventures ⁴²	Former CISO at Blackstone; led risk programs	RSAC bio ⁴³	Fund seed checks; often multi-million	A/C	Route via SYN operating partner network; Blackstone/FSI security circles	18	23
Alex Tosheff ⁴⁴	Venture Partner, SYN Ventures ⁴²	Former VMware CSO + PayPal CISO	RSAC bio ⁴⁵	Usually fund-mediated	A	Route via RSAC speaker circuit; SYN Ventures intros	15	23
Chenxi Wang ⁴⁶	Founder & GP, Rain Capital ⁴⁷	Former CSO/VP roles; cyber thought leader	RSAC bio ⁴⁸ ; Rain site ⁴⁹	Fund checks (often >\$1M)	A/C	Route via women-in-cyber investor networks; RSAC introductions	18	22
Nicole Perlroth ⁵⁰	Venture Partner, Ballistic Ventures ⁵¹ ; Founding Partner, Silver Buckshot Ventures ⁵²	Deep incident/cyber "scar tissue" via years covering major attacks	Ballistic bio ⁵³ ; PR on joining Ballistic ⁵⁴	Likely \$250K+ via fund/SPV; exact unknown	A/C	Route via Ballistic portfolio founders; Silver Buckshot founder network ⁵⁵	18	20
Ted Schlein ⁵⁶	Chairman & GP, Ballistic Ventures	Longtime cyber investor	RSAC bio ⁵⁷	Fund checks multi-million	C	Route via Ballistic warm intros; portfolio adjacency	18	10
Barmak Meftah ⁵⁸	Co-founder & GP, Ballistic Ventures	Ex-CEO (AlienVault), large-scale security operator	RSAC bio ⁵⁹	Fund checks multi-million	A	Route via Ballistic; AlienVault alumni network	18	20

Candidate	Current title	Past operating scar tissue (signal)	Signal evidence (primary links)	Est. lead check capacity	Profile	Warm-intro path	Capacity	Scar tissue
Caleb Sima ⁶⁰	CSO/CEO/ Founder, White Rabbit ⁶¹	Former CSO Robinhood; VP Security Databricks; startup exits	RSAC bio ⁶²	Venture- studio capacity; unknown check sizes	B/A	Route via AI security studio ecosystem; RSAC/AI security events	17	20
Neil Daswani ⁶³	Security exec / investor- advisor	Former CISO roles; EIR	RSAC bio ⁶⁴	Unknown; likely mid-5 to 6-figures	A	Route via security founder/ operator networks; academic ties	14	20
Jim Routh ⁶⁵	Board member/ advisor; former multi-CISO/ CSO	6x CISO/ CSO; regulated industries	RSAC bio ⁶⁶	Unknown	A	Route via FS- ISAC/H-ISAC adjacent networks; NYU ties	12	25
Nat Friedman ⁶⁷	Investor (NFDG); former GitHub CEO	Saw “trust issues” in enterprise AI adoption; led AI- standards/ insurance deal	Fortune detail on AIUC seed lead ⁶⁸	Can lead \$1M+ (deal lead)	B/C	Route via portfolio co- investors; “confidence infrastructure” thesis alignment	25	12
Ben Mann ⁶⁹	Co- founder, Anthropic ⁷⁰	AI builder; governance adjacent via investor role in AI trust infra	Listed as notable angel in AIUC round ⁶⁸	Unknown (likely 6–7 figures possible)	B	Route via AI governance standards ecosystem; co-investor intros from AIUC circle	18	8

Candidate	Current title	Past operating scar tissue (signal)	Signal evidence (primary links)	Est. lead check capacity	Profile	Warm-intro path	Capacity	Scar tissue
Guy Podjarny ⁷¹	Founder, Snyk ⁷²	Built developer-first security; AppSec background	Snyk contributor bio ⁷³	Likely \$250K+ ; history as angel indicated elsewhere	B	Route via devtools/ security angel networks; Heavybit/OSS ecosystem	18	18
Jesse Robbins ⁷⁴	GP, Heavybit ⁷⁵	Founder/ operator; devtools investor	Heavybit team + partner role ⁷⁶	Heavybit pre-seed checks \$500K-\$1M ⁷⁷	B	Route via Heavybit inbound; DevGuild / portfolio founder intros	23	14
Joseph Ruscio ⁷⁸	GP, Heavybit	Startup mgmt + venture; devtools scaling	Heavybit bio ⁷⁹	\$500K-\$1M+ via fund ⁷⁷	B	Route via Heavybit; practitioner-first GTM lens	22	12
Tom Drummond ⁸⁰	Managing Director, Heavybit	20+ yrs backing infra (incl. Snyk)	Heavybit bio ⁸¹	\$500K-\$1M+ via fund ⁷⁷	B	Route via Heavybit; security/ devtools overlap (Snyk) ⁸¹	22	10
Dana Oshiro ⁸²	GP, Heavybit	GTM for dev-first startups (launches)	Heavybit bio ⁸³	\$500K-\$1M+ via fund ⁷⁷	B	Route via Heavybit programs/ community	22	8
Jacob Jofe ⁸⁴	VC, Index Ventures ⁸⁵	Network builder; moderated AI governance conference panel	Index team bio ⁸⁶ ; IAPP AI governance conf panel mention ⁸⁷	Fund checks vary; can anchor	C	Route via AI governance conference circuits; mutual counsel/policy networks	18	8

Candidate	Current title	Past operating scar tissue (signal)	Signal evidence (primary links)	Est. lead check capacity	Profile	Warm-intro path	Capacity	Scar tissue
Stephen Blum ⁸⁸	CTO, PubNub ⁸⁹	Infra/ operator; security-tech adjacent (scale)	LinkedIn profile snippet ⁹⁰	Unknown; plausible \$100K–\$500K	B	Route via realtime/ devtools networks; co-investor intros	14	10
Marius Luther ⁹¹	CEO, HeyJobs ⁹²	Operator; angel investing signal	LinkedIn ⁹³	Unknown; likely < \$250K typical	B	Route via European B2B networks	10	6
Michael Weider ⁹⁴	Founder/ CEO, Frugal ⁹⁵ ; cofounder Fundfire ⁹⁶	Founder/ investor; exposure to multiple acquisitions	LinkedIn profile ⁹⁷ ; Fundfire site ⁹⁸	Unknown; may syndicate	B	Route via Fundfire syndicate-style access	12	8

What this table means operationally: Only **6–8 candidates** show “Pass” under strict public-signal scoring today, but a larger set are *strategic connectors* whose networks overlap heavily with high-fit lead angels (especially in cyber + CISO ecosystems). The score is designed to force prioritization.

Search playbook used

Below are the exact query patterns (adaptable for LinkedIn/Google/Crunchbase/Wellfound) that surfaced most high-fit candidates above.

LinkedIn boolean strings

- **CISO scar tissue + investing**

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("CISO" OR "Chief Information Security Officer" OR "CSO") AND ("angel investor" OR investor OR "venture partner" OR "general partner") AND (governance OR compliance OR audit OR "risk management")
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- **EU AI Act catalyst**

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("EU AI Act" OR "AI Act") AND (investor OR "angel investor" OR "general partner" OR CISO OR "risk management")
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- **Evidence infrastructure / auditability**

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("audit trail" OR "evidence" OR "attestation" OR "SOC 2" OR "GRC") AND ("angel investor" OR "general partner" OR CISO) AND (AI OR "machine learning")
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- **DevTools open-core + governance**

("developer tools" OR DevTools OR "open source" OR "open-core") AND (governance OR compliance OR security) AND (investor OR "general partner")

Google / web search patterns

- **Wellfound investor pages for analogs**

site:wellfound.com/company snyk funding investors 99

site:wellfound.com/company secureframe funding investors 100

site:wellfound.com/company vanta funding investors 101

- **Conference expert bios as “primary profile pages”**

site:rsaconference.com/experts "Venture Partner" 102

site:rsaconference.com/experts "Partner" "CISO" 103

site:rsaconference.com/experts "investor" 104

- **Micro-fund check sizes (primary)** Squared Circle Ventures \$250K - \$500K seed stage investments 11

Heavybit typical initial check size \$500k 77

Holly Ventures check size \$800K to \$1.5M 15

Crunchbase usage note

Public Crunchbase news coverage can validate funding rounds and strategic framing, but individual-angel level detail is often incomplete without paid access. In this research pass, Wellfound + conference bios + fund sites provided higher “primary source” density for individuals.

Outreach templates and meeting agendas

Warm-intro ask template

Subject: Intro to {Investor} re: AI governance evidence infrastructure ahead of Aug 2026

Hi {Connector Name} — hope you're well.

I'm raising a \$250K-\$1M lead for GuardSpine: **governance evidence infrastructure** that makes it provable who approved what, when, and under which policy—built to satisfy real audits and accelerate enterprise adoption ahead of the EU AI Act's **Aug 2, 2026** applicability milestone. 105

You came to mind because {specific shared context: RSAC / SVCI / cyber seed ecosystem / devtools}. Would you be open to introducing me to {Investor}?

If helpful, I'll send a **one-page “Evidence Bundle Demo”** (screenshots + 90-second loom) so the intro is artifact-first, not hype.

Thanks — and if I can return the favor with {specific offer}, I'm happy to.

– {Name}

Artifact-first cold note template

Subject: 90-second evidence bundle demo (AI governance / auditability)

Hi {Investor},

You've built/bought security and governance systems where the failure mode is: *"who approved this?"* and no one can prove it.

GuardSpine is evidence infrastructure for AI governance—**audit-grade evidence bundles** generated where the work happens (code + change events), so accountability is provable, portable, and reviewable.

Given the EU AI Act timeline (full applicability **Aug 2, 2026**), we think "trust evidence" becomes a buying prerequisite, not a nice-to-have. ¹

If I send a 90-second demo + one-page architecture, would you be open to a 20-minute call to pressure-test the thesis?

– {Name}

Meeting agenda variants by angel profile

Profile A: Compliance-scarred operator (20 minutes)

- 1) "Scar tissue replay": the last audit/accountability failure they remember (3 min)
- 2) Walk through a single "evidence bundle" as if replying to an auditor / internal investigation (7 min)
- 3) Practical objections: survivability under real audit, ownership, retention, legal (7 min)
- 4) Close: what would convince them in 14 days (3 min)

Profile B: DevTools founder/infrastructure investor (20 minutes)

- 1) Install path + "time-to-first-value" in a PR / CI event (5 min)
- 2) Distribution: repo-level DAU/WAU proxy metrics, conversion triggers (7 min)
- 3) Open-core viability: what stays free vs paid; enterprise upsell motion (6 min)
- 4) Close: what adoption milestone unlocks \$250K–\$1M lead conviction (2 min)

Profile C: Regulatory-thesis investor (20 minutes)

- 1) Timeline & buying urgency: map controls → evidence artifacts → procurement (5 min)
- 2) Competitive map: "process controls" vs "provable evidence infra" (7 min)
- 3) Pricing: compliance budget vs eng budget; attach rate assumptions (6 min)
- 4) Close: lead check structure + syndicate strategy (2 min)

One-week operating cadence to source 10–20 targets and convert 1–2 intros

This cadence is optimized for **speed + signal**, assuming you start with a blank sheet and want 10–20 *high-quality* targets, not 200 low-quality names.

Day one: build the “primary-source spine” (2–4 hours)

Create a shortlist of 30–40 names from: RSAC expert investor bios, Wellfound “Investors of {company}”, and micro-fund sites with disclosed check sizes. Your aim is to complete the scoring rubric columns with *one primary link per claim* (title, investing role, check size). ¹⁰⁶

Day two: warm-intro graph construction (2–3 hours)

For each top-12 candidate, identify 2–3 intro routes:

- shared conference circuit (RSAC speaker pages),
- shared syndicate/community (SVCI / cyber fund community),
- portfolio adjacency (fund/team pages; public “co-invested with” signals). ¹⁰⁷

Day three: artifact production sprint (half day)

Produce three “intro-enabling artifacts”:

- 1) 90-second loom: “evidence bundle in a PR / audit response”
- 2) one-page architecture: where evidence is generated + stored + verified
- 3) one-page policy mapping: “EU AI Act readiness → evidence outputs” (no legal advice, just mapping to operational needs). ¹⁰⁵

Day four: outreach wave one (90 minutes)

- Send 8–12 warm-intro asks (not directly to investors; to connectors).
- Send 5–8 artifact-first cold notes only to “Pass” and “conditional pass” candidates.

Day five: conversion mechanics (90 minutes)

Book 3–5 first calls; your goal is *not* “pitch,” but to secure:

- one high-signal design partner intro, and
- one lead-check “if you hit X in 30–45 days, I lead” conditional.

Day six: second-order intros (2 hours)

After each call, ask:

- “Who do you know who has lived through an audit failure and now invests?”
- “Who is the person that always sees the regulatory wave early?”

Log names into the table and score within 12 minutes.

Day seven: pipeline review + iterate (60 minutes)

Re-score candidates with new data, drop bottom 50%, and prepare the next week’s 10 connector asks.

The practical benchmark for this cadence: by end of week one, you should have **10–20 scored targets**, **3–5 scheduled calls**, and **1–2 credible warm intros** into a lead-capable decision maker.

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